



SSA STARTER KIT

*A simple, step-by-step guide to start your
Social Security disability application.*

HOW TO START

THE STEPS

WHAT YOU NEED

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Supporting Families, Building Futures.

1 Welcome

Applying for disability benefits can feel hard. There are many forms. There are many rules. And the words can be hard to understand.

This kit makes it simple. It shows you how to start, what happens step by step, and what papers to get ready. Read one part at a time. Check things off as you go.

You can use this kit on your own. If you want help at any point, Southern Oak can walk with you through the whole process.

2 Words to Know

- **SSA** — the Social Security Administration. This is the government office that runs the program.
- **SSDI** — benefits for people who worked and paid into Social Security, and now cannot work because of a health problem.
- **SSI** — benefits for people with a disability who have low income and few resources.
- **DDS** — the state office that reads your medical records and helps SSA decide your case.
- **Appeal** — asking SSA to look at your case again after a no (a denial).

3 How to Start

Do these five things first. They will make the rest much easier.

- **1. Know the basic rule.** To qualify, your health problem must keep you from working in a real way. It must be expected to last at least 12 months, or be a condition that will lead to death.
- **2. Make a free account.** Go to ssa.gov and make a “my Social Security” account. You will use it to apply and to check your case.
- **3. Pick how you will apply.** You can apply online at ssa.gov, by phone at 1-800-772-1213, or at your local Social Security office.
- **4. Write down the first day you contact SSA.** This date can protect your benefits. Keep it in a safe place.
- **5. Start a folder.** Put your name and the date on it. Every letter and form goes in this folder from day one.
- **6. Write your story on one page.** When did your health problem start? When did you stop work, or cut your hours? What doctors have you seen? This one page will help you answer most of the questions on the forms.

4 The Steps, One by One

- **Step 1 — You apply.** You fill out the application and a form called the Adult Disability Report. It asks about your health problems, your medicines, your doctors, and the jobs you had in the last 5 years.
- **Step 2 — SSA checks the basic facts.** SSA makes sure you meet the work and income rules. Then they send your case to DDS.
- **Step 3 — DDS reads your medical records.** A case worker and doctors at DDS read your records. They may ask your doctors for more records. They may also ask you to see one of their doctors for a short exam. This exam is free.

- **Step 4 — You get a letter.** SSA mails you a letter that says yes or no. Many people get a no the first time. A no is not the end.
- **Step 5 — If the letter says no, you can appeal.** This first appeal is called Reconsideration. You have 60 days from the date on the letter to ask. Send any new medical records with it.
- **Step 6 — If the answer is still no, you can ask for a hearing.** A judge will hear your case. You have 60 days from the date on the letter to ask for the hearing. Good records and good prep matter a lot here.
- **Step 7 — If the answer is yes, your benefits start.** SSA sends a letter that tells you how much you will get and when your pay starts. Read the “How Long Does It Take?” part of this kit to see the time frames.

5 How Long Does It Take?

Every case is different. These are common time frames, not promises.

- **First decision:** most people wait about 3 to 6 months. Some wait longer.
- **If you appeal (Reconsideration):** this can take a few more months.
- **If you ask for a hearing:** the wait for a hearing can be many months. The whole process, from start to finish, can take 1 to 2 years for some people.
- **If you are approved for SSDI:** there is a 5-month waiting period. It starts with the first full month after the date SSA says your disability began. Your first check comes after that wait.
- **If you are approved for SSI:** pay can start the month after you applied, or the month after you are found eligible, whichever is later.

While you wait, keep going to your doctors. Keep taking your medicine. Your new records become part of your case and can help you.

6 What You Need — Paper Checklist

Get what you can before you apply. If a paper is missing, do not wait. You can still apply, and add papers later.

About you

- Your Social Security number
- Proof of your age, like a birth certificate or passport
- Citizenship or legal status papers, if they apply to you
- Marriage or divorce papers, and facts about your children, if they apply
- Your bank account facts, so SSA can pay you by direct deposit

About your health

- Names, addresses, and phone numbers of all your doctors, clinics, hospitals, and therapists
- The dates they treated you, and what they treated you for

- A list of all your medicines, who gave them to you, and what each one is for
- Test results you already have, like labs, X-rays, MRI, or CT scans

About your work and your day

- The jobs you had in the last 5 years, what you did at each job, and the dates
- Your most recent tax return or W-2, if you have it
- Notes on what your health problem stops you from doing: sitting, standing, walking, lifting, focusing, remembering
- Names of family or friends who see what your days are like — SSA may ask for them

7 Tips That Help Your Case

- **Go to your doctor visits.** Your medical records are the base of your case.
- **Do not miss a deadline.** When a letter comes, write the 60-day appeal date on a calendar that same day.
- **Open your mail fast.** Some SSA forms must be sent back in about 10 days.
- **Tell the truth, in detail.** Say what a normal day looks like. Say what you can do, what you cannot do, and how long things take you.
- **Keep a copy of everything** you send, with the date you sent it.

8 When You Want Help

This kit helps you start. If you want an advocate to help you get your records in order, fill out the forms with you, and walk with you step by step, Southern Oak offers full **SSA Application Assistance**. More help is there if you need it.

You can also book a **30-minute appointment (\$40.00)** to talk about your case and your choices first.

Apply or reach us: southernoakfw.org • (956)-624-3790 • southernoakfw@gmail.com • San Antonio, Texas — serving San Antonio and surrounding areas. Mon–Thurs by appointment; Fri 9 am–4 pm CT.

Legal Disclaimer — Please Read

We are not lawyers. Southern Oak Financial & Wellness is not a law firm. Jessica Alvarez is not a legal attorney. We do not give legal advice. This kit is for learning only. It is general facts about the process. It is not advice about your own case. If you need legal advice, talk to a licensed attorney.

We cannot promise a result. We do not and cannot guarantee that your application will be approved. We do not guarantee any benefit amount or any date. Only the Social Security

Administration decides who is approved. Every case is different.

Times can change. The time frames in this kit are common ranges based on how long cases often take. Your case may be faster or slower. Rules, forms, and deadlines can change. Check ssa.gov or call SSA at 1-800-772-1213 for the newest facts.

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